mahagathbandhan (MGB), the alliance won a clear majority with 178 seats and a combined vote share of 41.8 per cent. The BJP, with a vote share of 24.4 per cent, won just 53 seats. In the 2019 Lok Sabha election, though, the JD(U) was allied with the BJP and the Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) under the NDA umbrella. The NDA won 39 of the 40 seats with a 53 per cent vote share. Of these, the BJP had 17, the JD(U) 16 and the LJP six. The scene has shifted decisively in favour of the Opposition with the return of the MGB whose combined vote share is likely to be 10 per cent more than what the BJP can get. That means it could lose a substantial number of the seats it won in 2019 if the MGB holds its nerve.

The BJP is acutely aware that in Bihar both Nitish and Tejashwi have their respective strong social bases. The RJD commands the formidable M-Y (Muslim-Yadav) axis whereas the JD(U) has a similar cohort of some of the backward castes, the Extremely Backward Castes (EBCs) and Mahadalits rallying behind Nitish. So, the BJP is adopting a triad of strategies to destabilise the MGB in Bihar. By using the central investigation agencies to revive corruption charges against Lalu and Tejashwi, it hopes to not only discredit the RJD but also turn the JD(U) legislators against it. The BJP is stirring the pot by saying that if Tejashwi emerges as the chief minister as promised by Nitish, the JD(U), as a force in the state, would be considerably diminished. After all, in the 2020 assembly election, the two parties had fought bitterly against each other. But after the CBI chargesheeted Lalu and Tejashwi, Nitish made it a point to arrive at the Bihar assembly with Tejashwi and his brother Tej Pratap Singh. That sent a clear message that the JD(U) alliance with the RJD remained intact and strong.

Opposition leaders suspect that the BJP is now trying to engineer a split in the JD(U). But with the combine enjoying a clear majority of 160 of the total 243 seats (a simple majority requires 122 seats), even a split in the 45-MLA JD(U) cannot bring down the government. Meanwhile, the BJP is chipping away at the base of these parties, by getting Jitan Ram Manjhi's Hindustani Awam Morcha (HAM) and, Upendra Kushwaha, leader of the newly formed Rashtriya Lok Janata Dal (RLJD), to walk out of their tie-up with the JD(U). By appointing Samrat Chaudhary as the state BJP president in March, the party hopes to wean away one component of Nitish's core constituency: the Koeri-Kushwaha voters who amount to 5 per cent of Bihar's electorate. The BJP is also banking on Modi's charisma to turn the tide in its favour, canvassing for a party with full majority to run the Centre rather than an unwieldy conglomeration of Opposition parties. In fact, by striking at Maharashtra's Sharad Pawar, who had emerged with Nitish as the fulcrum of Opposition unity, the BJP has considerably dented their plan to put together a credible and viable coalition. Psephologist Kumar believes Opposition unity efforts have got off to a slow start. As he puts it, "They should be doing a 100-metre sprint rather than treating this as a marathon."

In West Bengal, where the formidable Mamata Banerjee

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